own internal voice on that hilltop Burnley bench only five years ago, devilishly transformed into thousands of Australian accents.

This is the story that I know from the outside too. The Australians are the winners; the gloating, relentless, goading, frothing at the mouth for more winners. It is baked into who they are, never stopping for a second to consider the foot coming off the throat. England finishing second best to Australia is all I know. I understand the heartbreak and the longing and the self-punishment that comes from being an English cricket supporter completely. Now that I am inside, it plays out in a flash of verification, that the power dynamic is exactly how I imagined. They mould in my imagination to the boys from school too – surrounded by laughter, wondering who I am, as I wait, shrunk and small, an experience of nothing else but being less than.

The game is already looking ominously done by the time I am bowling to Adam Gilchrist in the 38th over. He has 124 and Australia are 240/1. I have, like everyone else, been spending my teens watching him, awestruck, as he put England teams to the sword. I run in. It's not a great ball, outside off stump. Gilchrist swings as freely as he has been all afternoon, as freely as he has been all decade, but this time he mistimes it and inside edges the ball on to his own stumps. In slight shock, I run towards the stumps, as if to check that is what has happened. The commentary team, unbeknownst to me, has called me Jimmy Adams as I do so. I've done it, I've taken a wicket, but still nobody knows my name.

By the time I have to bat, they can only find me a fielding helmet to wear. It's an extension of the cumbersome, strange-fit kit that my first game comes with. It has an extra bar across the front, just to really help impair my vision. I am squinting into the concrete blocks, trying to find any way of getting close to the rockets Brett Lee is throwing with a scuffed-up white ball under lights. I don't even see the one he bowls me with, just hear the clatter of the stumps and walk off, back into the cavernous abyss of the car park. It was like that walk back from school, shrugging and hoping that I'd be back.